

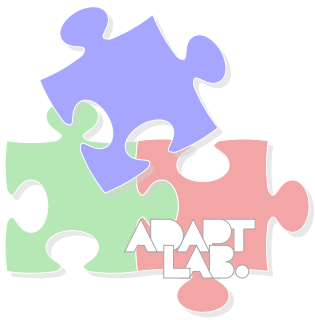
Employing Metaprogramming: A Macro-Driven Strategy to Overcome Compiler-Imposed Limitations on Specialization

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Computer Science Department
BSc in Computer Science

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L-31 - Computer Science
Academic Year 2024-2025





Specialization
State of the Art and Limitations

Specialization

Problem Statement

Proposal

By Example: Implementing the Proposal

Implementation Details

Limitations

Evaluation

Conclusions

Specialization aims to combine generic programming with type-specific optimizations.





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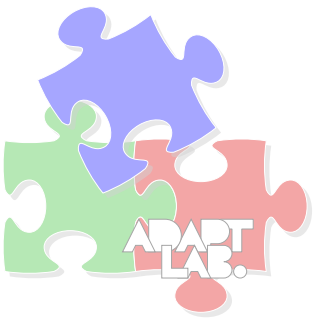
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Specialization aims to combine generic programming with type-specific optimizations.

Mechanisms vary widely, from mature and widely used systems to experimental features, with varying degrees of success.





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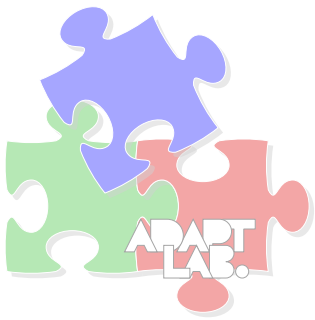
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Specialization aims to combine generic programming with type-specific optimizations.

Mechanisms vary widely, from mature and widely used systems to experimental features, with varying degrees of success.

In many modern ecosystems, specialization is often unstable, forcing a tradeoff between performance and compiler stability.





Problem Statement
What's happening in Rust?

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However, due to unresolved design issues and concerns about soundness of the type system, specialization is still unstable.



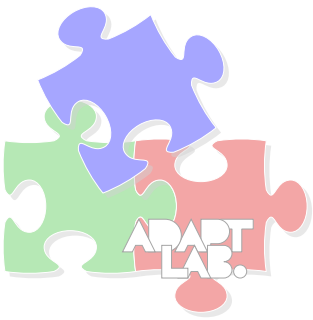


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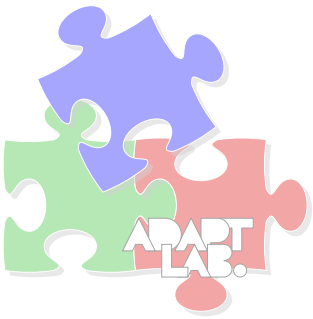
Without stable specialization, developers often resort to code duplication or complex workarounds.





Problem Statement
Motivational Example

Consider implementing a trait for different types, with a specialized implementation for a specific type.

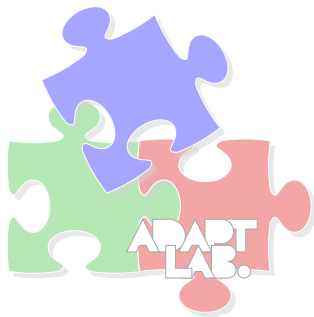




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5      }
6  }
7  impl MyTrait for i32 {
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10     }
11 }
12 fn main() {
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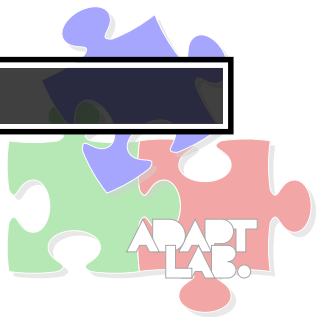


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```

```
error[E0119]: conflicting implementations of trait MyTrait for type i32
```

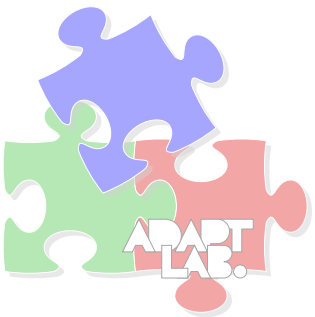




Proposal
Macro-Based Specialization

Employ the powerful metaprogramming capabilities of Rust to build a macro library that simulates native specialization, with:

- Native-like look and feel
- Compile-time resolution
- Sound and stable
- Monomorphization
- Powerful API



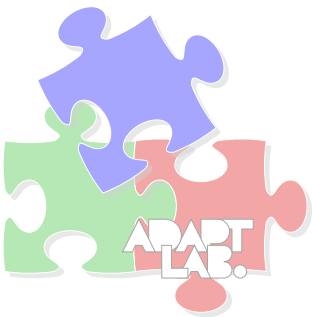


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To do this, we use two macros: `when` and `spec`.





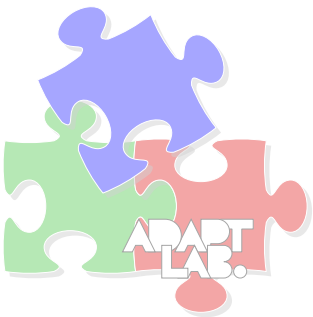
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The approach can also be applied to other languages or even directly into the compiler.



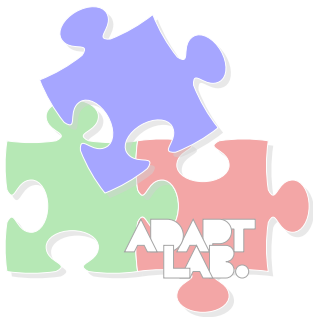


By Example: Implementing the Proposal

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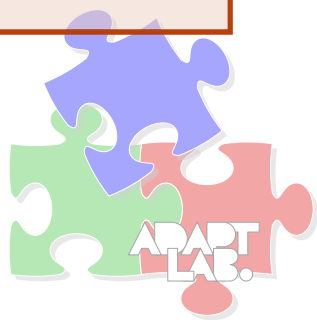




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2  impl<T> MyTrait for T {
3      fn my_method(&self) {
4          println!("Generic implementation");
5      }
6  }
7  #[when(T = i32)]
8  impl<T> MyTrait for T {
9      fn my_method(&self) {
10         println!("Specialized for i32");
11     }
12 }
13 fn main() {
14     spec! { 10.my_method(); i32 };        // prints "Specialized for i32"
15     spec! { 10.5.my_method(); f64 };      // prints "Generic implementation"
16 }
```



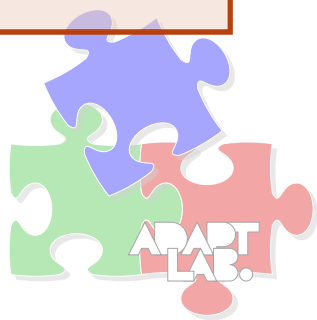


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2  impl<T> MyTrait for T {
3      fn my_method(&self) {
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5      }
6  }
7  trait MyTrait_i32 { fn my_method(&self); }
8  impl MyTrait_i32 for i32 {
9      fn my_method(&self) {
10         println!("Specialized for i32");
11     }
12 }
13 fn main() {
14     <i32 as MyTrait_i32>::my_method(&10); // prints "Specialized for i32"
15     <f64 as MyTrait>::my_method(&10.5);   // prints "Generic implementation"
16 }
```

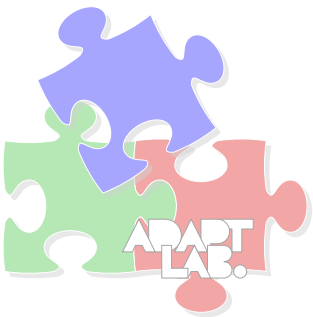




By Example: Implementing the Proposal
Supported Predicates and Forms

The following predicates are supported:

- `T = Type`
- `all(p1, p2, ...)`
- `not(p)`
- `T: Tr1 + Tr2`
- `any(p1, p2, ...)`





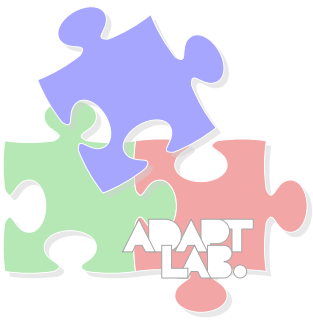
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- `T = Type`
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- `T: Tr1 + Tr2`
- `any(p1, p2, ...)`

We also support the following implementations forms:

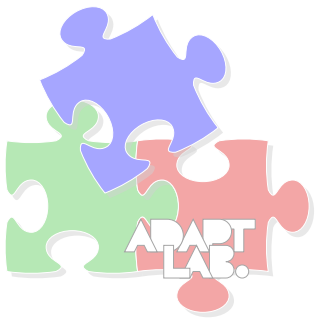
- `impl<T> Trait for T`
- `impl<T> Trait for Type<T>`
- `impl<T> Trait<T> for Type`





By Example: Implementing the Proposal
Lifetimes

Lifetimes are one of the main reasons native specialization is still unstable.

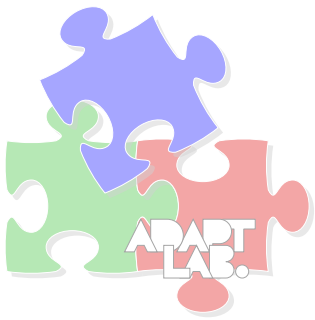




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Lifetimes bounds can be implicit or explicit.



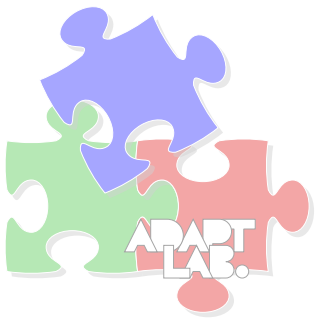


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Lifetimes bounds can be implicit or explicit.

In our belief, this is an architectural limitation of the compiler that can be overcome with proper re-design.





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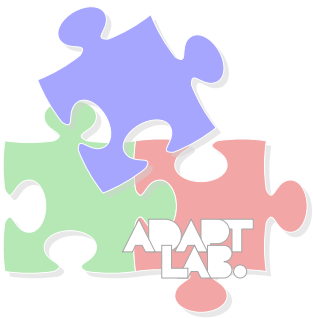
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Our proposal treats lifetimes as first-class citizens:

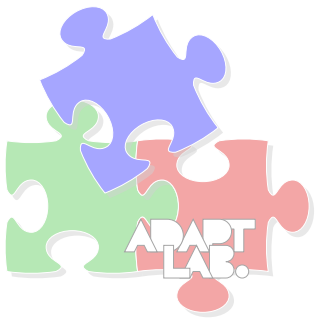
- `T = &'a _`
- `T: 'a`





By Example: Implementing the Proposal
Higher-Ranked Polymorphism

Our macro system also supports Higher-Ranked Polymorphism.

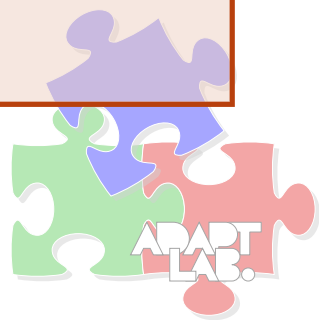




By Example: Implementing the Proposal
Higher-Ranked Polymorphism

Our macro system also supports Higher-Ranked Polymorphism.

```
1  struct S;
2  trait Trait<T, U, V> {
3      fn f(&self, t: T, u: U) -> V;
4  }
5  #[when(all(
6      T = &str, T: 'b,
7      U = for<'a> fn(T, &'a i32) -> V
8  ))]
9  impl<'b, T, U, V> Trait<T, U, V> for S {
10     fn f(&self, t: T, u: U) -> V {
11         u(t, &7)
12     }
13 }
14 fn main() {
15     let s = S;
16     let lambda = |a: &str, b: &i32| a.len() as i32 + *b;
17     let res: i32 = spec! { s.f("abc", lambda); S;
18       [&str, for<'a> fn(&str, &'a i32) -> i32] }; // returns 10
19 }
```

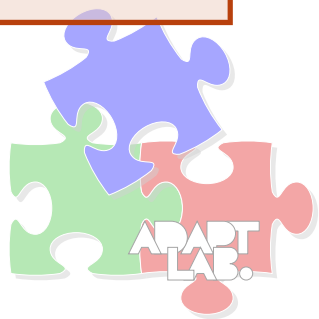




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```
1  struct S;
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3      fn f(&self, t: T, u: U) -> V;
4  }
5  trait Trait_fn<'b, V> {
6      fn f(&self, t: &'b str, u: for<'a> fn(&'b str, &'a i32) -> V) -> V;
7  }
8  impl<'b, V> Trait_fn<'b, V> for S {
9      fn f(&self, t: &'b str, u: for<'a> fn(&'b str, &'a i32) -> V) -> V {
10         u(t, &7)
11     }
12 }
13 fn main() {
14     let s = S;
15     let lambda = |a: &str, b: &i32| a.len() as i32 + *b;
16     let res: i32 = <S as Trait_fn<_>>::f(&s, "abc", lambda); // returns 10
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```

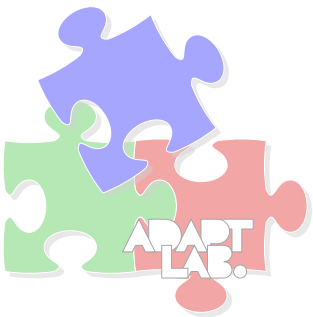




Implementation Details
Handling Conditional Implementations

Conditions defined in the `when` macro are normalized into DNF, flattening when possible, e.g.:

```
all(T = Vec<U>, any(U = i32, U = f64)) → any(T = Vec<i32>, T = Vec<f64>)
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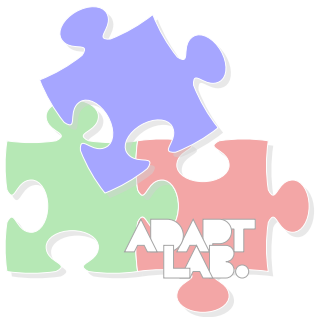
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A partial order defined over the predicates is used to determine the specificity of each implementation, e.g.:

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T = &i32 > T = &U > T: Copy
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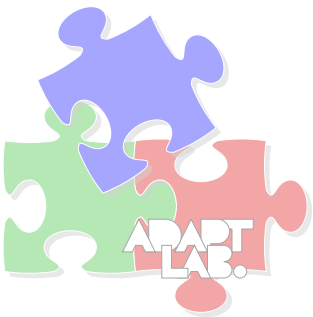
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```
T = &i32 > T = &U > T: Copy
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We need a way to collect all the traits defined in the crate and to handle the order of their implementations. In Rust, this is done with Build Scripts, e.g.:

```
mono_spec::handle_order();
```

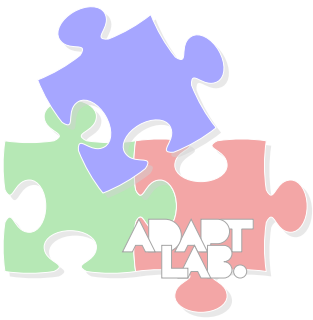




Limitations
Some Shortcomings

The usage of macros makes the tool flexible and powerful, but it also introduces some limitations and shortcomings, e.g.:

- Boilerplate
- Compile-Time Overhead
- Language Features Support
- Same Project Traits
- Trait Bounds





Evaluation
Approach

Once identified some patterns, we instrumented the compiler to analyze at HIR level any function definition.

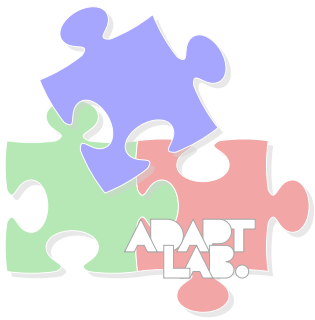




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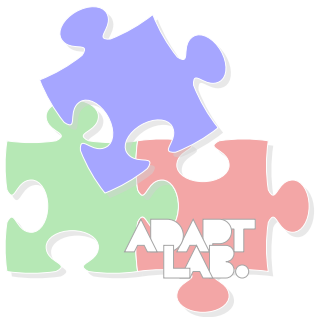
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We then calculated the tree edit distance using the ZSS algorithm and from that, we derived a similarity score:

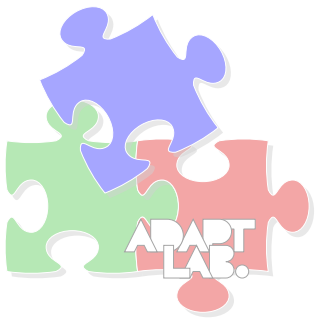
$$1 - \frac{\text{dist}}{\text{max size}}$$





Evaluation
Results

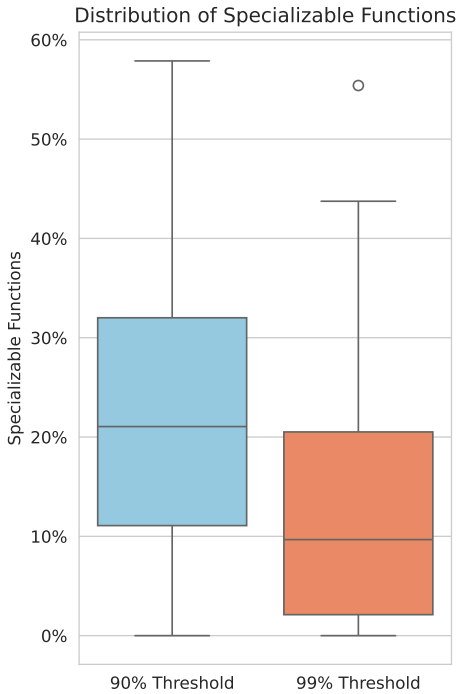
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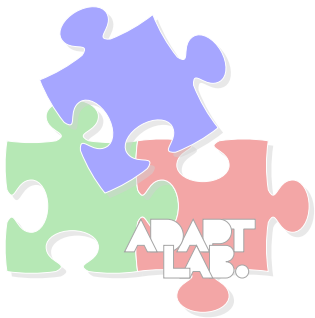




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Results

The analysis was run twice on 65 open-source Rust codebases: with a similarity threshold of 90% and 99% respectively.

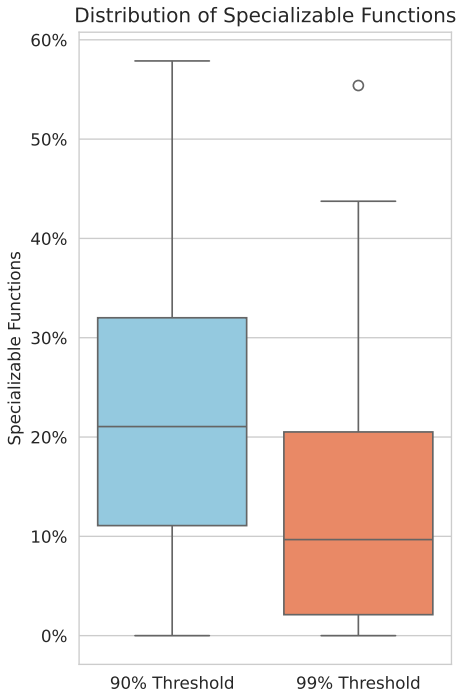


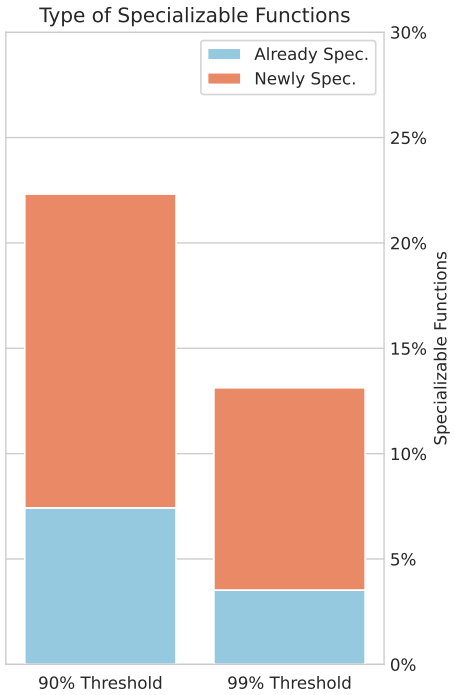


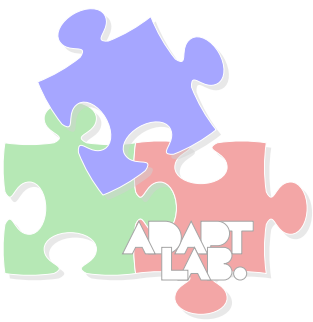


Evaluation
Results

The analysis was run twice on 65 open-source Rust codebases: with a similarity threshold of 90% and 99% respectively.



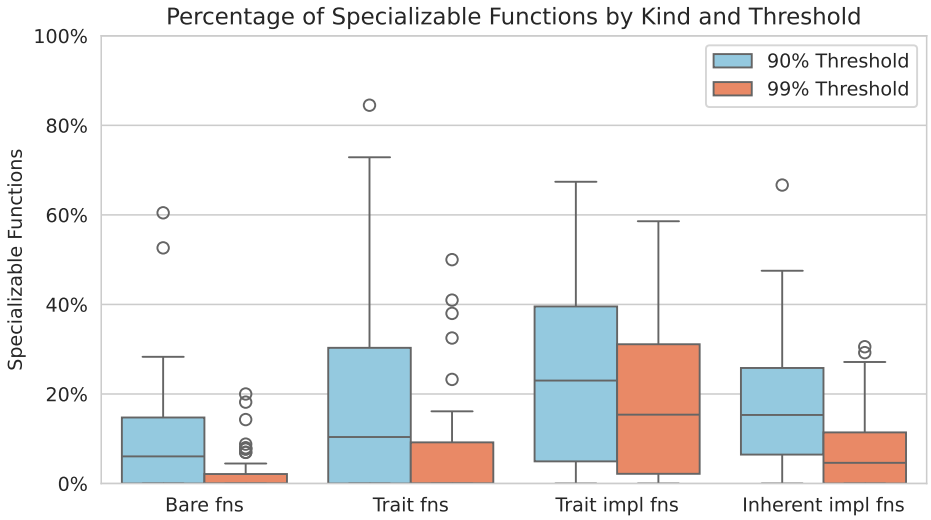


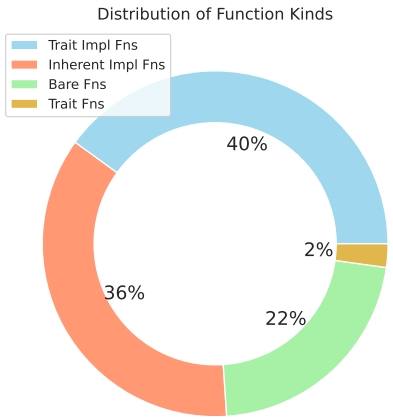


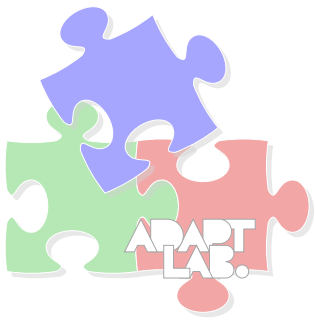


Evaluation
Results

We then analyzed the kinds of functions that were found to be specializable.









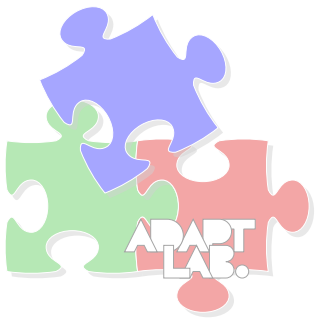
Conclusions

Interesting results:

- We are writing an article (Meta-Monomorphizing Specializations), to be submitted to ECOOP.

Future work:

- Extend the tool to support other language features and function kinds.





Thanks for your attention!

